much capital-intensive … We will be looking more at technology-intensive and skill-intensive areas.'

With these two main directional points of focus, Ratan sought to primarily confine direct action of the plan to the areas in which TIL or its associates operated. The common foundation of both the plans was making technology the engine of growth.

This technology-focused approach was evaluated as 'valid and relevant' to aid in 'achieving a leadership position in relation to the emerging opportunities in the 1990s'. With these identified focus areas, the plan laid out TIL's mission as entering and managing 'technology based businesses in emerging opportunity areas', serving as a catalyst for 'inducting new technology based activities into Group companies', and becoming 'one of the apex investment companies to supplement, support and protect Tata shareholding in Group companies'. It also sought to provide 'inputs in the areas of Strategic Planning, Human Resource Management, Treasury & Legal, and Budgetary Controls to companies associated with TIL'.

In the two plans, Ratan had identified new opportunities, exhibiting a farsightedness similar to Nusserwanji Tata and Jamsetji Tata. The identification of business opportunities in the mammoth logistics required for the British Abyssinian campaign by the father–son duo had provided Jamsetji with the funds to mark the beginning of the Tata Group. Ratan's identification of opportunities had a striking similarity.

But, like the earlier plan, the new version of the Strategic Plan had few supporters. Even JRD shied away from endorsing Ratan's vision for the group. When Ratan sent a note to him in January 1990, informing him of his intention to update his 1983 Plan, JRD advised him to restrict its scope to 'relatively modest schemes likely to interest mainly … Tata Companies'. In reality, JRD was loathe to disrupt the tenuous balance that existed between the large operating companies and Tata Sons.

As he later told a leading newspaper: 'I think it [the Tata Group] should continue as it is today. I believe that this is going to happen because my colleagues have the same beliefs as I have. Yes, there may be mental competition between some of them. It means that everyone does not necessarily agree totally with the approach of others. But this is to be expected.'

The new plan was carefully worded to prevent any misconstruction that Ratan was attempting to 'build an empire'. The team paid particular